CHAPTER 25

PIETERSEN AND MOORES

When Michael Vaughan retires in the middle of the South Africa series in 2008, there are only four days until the next Test match. ‘It’s the hardest decision I’ve ever had to make, but also the easiest,’ he tells the press conference. It is the first time I watch on at a retirement, knowing that it will one day happen to me, but not really believing it yet, feeling the curiosity and rush of the unknown as he breaks down speaking about his family. Daniella is pregnant again, five months in now, and life is awash with beginnings and endings, possibilities and problems. In the days that unfold, Kevin Pietersen is appointed the new captain of England. Paul Collingwood retires from his one-day role too, meaning that Pietersen is given captaincy of both in a matter of days.

Pietersen and Peter Moores could not be more different. Having not done it himself at the highest level, as well as being handicapped slightly at times by his own kindness, Moores has had moments of struggling to earn the entire respect of the dressing room. I feel this is unfair, but it is something that is often thick in the air. He will stay up through the night, working out strategies, and first thing in the morning be full of ideas and enthusiasm about bowling plans. Everything he says makes sense, but I am reaching a time in my career when I don’t feel like I need too much input, and sometimes I feel it has the potential to cloud minds.

His approach, a real dedication and desperation to prove he is doing everything he could to make the team successful, is opposed to Pietersen, who, as brilliant as he is, we always feel has his own agenda. The partnership, over the next few months, unfolds exactly as the dressing room fears. They are not successful, struggling in games, and when we go home from India because of the Mumbai terrorist attacks, Kevin phones us all